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EPISODE 23

Folding a Talet on Shabbat

By Morris Arking · Oct 31, 2019

In Shulhan 'Arukh, Maran prohibits folding clothing on Shabbat, since it's a form of Metakken, fixing, since it's done to prevent and remove wrinkles. However, Maran allows one to fold clothing if he doesn't fold it on the actual folds, the way it's normally folded. If he folds it not on the crease, Maran allows it.

So based on that, there are those that fold their Talet only not on the crease. They won't fold it on the crease on Shabbat.

Although the general rule is that we follow the ruling of Maran in Shulhan 'Arukh, in this case, the custom of Halab was to be lenient and to actually fold the Talet on the creases, to fold it the normal way. And this is based on the opinion of the Kol Bo, one of the Rishonim that Maran himself quotes in his longer work known as the Bet Yosef. According to the Kol Bo, our folding that we do in our times is different than the folding that they did in the times of the Talmud, because in the times of the Talmud, they would actually actively work to remove the wrinkles. We just fold it. So if you just fold it on the creases, you're not doing anything active to try to remove the wrinkles, then it's permissible. So even though Maran doesn't rule like the Kol Bo, our custom is like the Kol Bo, we fold our Talet on Shabbat in the normal way.

This custom was recorded by Ribbi Hayyim Attieh. Ribbi Hayyim Attieh lived in the 18th century in Halab, and he wrote a book Orshot HaHayyim, and it's recorded in his book Orshot HaHayyim. It's also recorded by Ribbi Eliyahu Hamway, who lived in the end of the 19th century and the beginning of the 20th century. He records this custom in his book Peh Eliyahu. It's also recorded by Ribbi Hayyim Menashe Sethon. His book is Eress Hayyim, and it's actually a book of customs of Eress Yisrael. It's not a book of the customs of Halab, but he records it there as the custom of Eress Yisrael. We also find it recorded by Ribbi Yisshak Palacci in his book Yafeh LaLeb. He was an authority from Turkey in the 19th century.

So therefore, our custom of folding our Talet the regular way on Shabbat, on the creases, it's a valid custom, it's based on halakhic sources, and one is not obligated to follow Maran's opinion in this exceptional case.

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